

NORTH WALES CRUSADERS RLFC

OFFICIAL MATCH DAY PROGRAMME



SALFORD

SUNDAY 31st MAY
15:00





Chairman:
Jamie El-Kaleh

General Manager:
Conrad Anderson

Head Coach:
Sean Long

Assistant Coach:
Martin Fisher

Programme Editor:
Lee Kirkman

Honours:

North Wales Crusaders (2026)

Survived

2026

North Wales Crusaders (2011)

League 1 Winners

2013, 2025

League 1 Cup Winners

2015

League 1 Cup Runners Up

2017

Celtic Crusaders (2006)

National League 1 Runners Up

2008

National League 2 Winners

2007

Chairman's Welcome

Welcome to our first home fixture under the new company.

It is an honour to be writing these notes for today's matchday programme, and I could not be more thankful for the immense support we have received from everyone during the initial phase of our take-over. The backing from our fans has been nothing short of incredible, providing us with a formidable foundation from which we can now build and grow.

On a personal note, today's fixture carries a unique significance for me. During my time working in Rugby League, I was fortunate enough to serve as the lead performance analyst at Salford ironically, during the very season we secured victory in the Million Pound Game. It is funny how things work out in this sport. To now stand here as the owner of the Crusaders and welcome them as our opposition for our first home game is a very special full-circle moment.

I want to place on record my deepest gratitude to our dedicated group of volunteers. You have continually gone above and beyond to ensure that North Wales Crusaders remains a living, breathing club for this current campaign.

Equal credit must be directed to our staff and playing squad. Competing in challenging fixtures against the likes of Batley and Goole is a formidable task at the best of times, let alone when we have literally been pulling a team together at the shortest of notice. The commitment and resilience shown across the board have been outstanding.

Make no mistake, our primary objective for this current cycle is survival. We have a monumental task ahead of us, but we will approach it step by step. Together, we are going to create one of the greatest comeback stories in Rugby League.

Enjoy the game.

THE CLUB THAT WOULDN'T DIE



North Wales Crusaders are delighted to announce that long-standing volunteer and supporter Conrad Anderson has been appointed Interim General Manager until the end of the season.

In this part-time role, Conrad will work closely with the local community, supporters, volunteers, partners and shareholders, while helping to build strong foundations for the future of the club. He will also act as a communication bridge between supporters and Chairman Jamie El-Kaleh.

Chairman and owner Jamie El-Kaleh said:

“Conrad stepping into the Interim General Manager role is exactly what North Wales Crusaders need right now. Understanding the heartbeat of this club is paramount, and nobody loves it more than he does.

“Conrad is my eyes and ears on the ground, and I have absolute confidence in his ability to help us build this new era.”

Conrad Anderson said: “This club means everything to me. North Wales Crusaders is more than just a rugby league club — it’s a family and a community.

“Our supporters are the heartbeat of this club, and I will give absolutely everything I have to help drive us forward. I want fans to feel proud, connected and excited about the future again. “This club has been through difficult times, but the passion is still here, the fight is still here, and together we can build something really special.”

“North Wales Crusaders is more than just a rugby league club - it’s a family and a community”



THIS SPORTING LIFE

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For long enough, rugby league in Wales has existed somewhere between dream and defiance. A sport forever battling for space in a nation where rugby union is stitched into the national identity, yet somehow refusing to die. Every few years, somebody declares it finished in Wales. Every few years, it drags itself back up again.

The story of rugby league in Wales is not one of domination or wealth. It is a story of survival.

For many people, Welsh rugby begins and ends with the union game. The valleys, the old coal towns, the packed clubhouses on a Saturday afternoon, the ghosts of Grand Slams and Lions tours. Rugby union became part of Welsh culture in a way few sports ever manage. League, by comparison, was always treated as the outsider, the professional code, the northern game, the one viewed with suspicion for decades.

Yet Wales has always produced rugby league talent.

Long before the modern era, Welsh players crossed the divide to play in the professional game in northern England. Legends such as Billy Boston became icons of the sport, even if many back home barely appreciated just how great they were. Boston, born in Cardiff, became one of rugby league's immortals at Wigan Warriors, scoring tries at a rate most players could only dream of. Others followed the same road north, chasing opportunity, wages, and a different version of rugby life.

That relationship between Wales and rugby league has always been complicated. Wales produces players naturally suited to league, strong runners, tough defenders, instinctive rugby brains; but the sport itself has struggled to build permanent roots.

There have been flashes when it looked like things might truly take off.

The early years of the Celtic Crusaders felt revolutionary. For the first time, Wales had a club with genuine ambition, climbing through the British rugby league pyramid and eventually reaching the Super League. Crowds in Bridgend were never massive, but there was curiosity, excitement, and the feeling that maybe rugby league had finally found a home west of the Severn Bridge.

But Welsh rugby league has often been undone by instability as much as opposition. Financial issues, questionable ownership, relocation after relocation, Bridgend, Newport, Wrexham — meant the Crusaders never truly settled. Supporters were expected to constantly start again, and eventually the dream collapsed under the weight of mismanagement and uncertainty.

Yet even then, rugby league in Wales refused to disappear.

Out of the ashes came North Wales Crusaders, carrying the torch in Wrexham. It exists on smaller budgets and with far less glamour, but perhaps with a clearer understanding of reality. Semi-professional rugby league in Wales is not about becoming the next sporting giant overnight. It is about community, persistence, and giving players an opportunity to play the game.

South Wales has continued to fight as well, through clubs, development sides, and grass-roots setups that rarely receive headlines or financial backing. Volunteers keep much of the sport alive. Coaches give up evenings for little reward. Players travel huge distances because they love the game.

That passion matters because rugby league offers something different in Wales. The sport has always appealed to those who feel slightly outside the traditional rugby union establishment. It is often more working class, more direct, less obsessed with old hierarchies and traditions. Rugby league people tend to carry a siege mentality in Wales because they have had to.

Internationally, Wales has produced moments that remind everyone of the potential still there. The Welsh national side has never been among the elite consistently, but it has had days where it has punched far above its weight. Reaching the semi-finals of the 1995 Rugby League World Cup remains one of the greatest achievements in Welsh rugby history, regardless of code.

Even today, there are signs of life.

The growth of junior participation, the increasing visibility of rugby league through television and social media, and the continued production of talented Welsh players all suggest the sport still has a future. Wales may never become a rugby league powerhouse like parts of northern England or eastern Australia, but it does not need to be.

What rugby league in Wales needs more than anything is stability. Stable clubs. Stable leadership. Stable pathways for young players. The talent has always existed. The problem has been building structures strong enough to keep it in Wales.

And perhaps that is why rugby league suits Wales so well after all.

Because both share a stubbornness. A refusal to accept limitations placed upon them by others. The sport survives because enough people still care deeply about it. Because somewhere in towns across Wales, there are still kids picking up a rugby ball who might one day fall in love with league instead of union.

Rugby league in Wales has never had the easy road. It has lurched from optimism to disaster more times than anybody can count. But it is still here.

And that, in itself, says everything.



The Club That Wouldn't Die

Welcome to Stadium CSM for the first home game of our new club.

It feels surreal to be back here. The last time we gathered at this ground, we were a different entity entirely, and for a while it genuinely looked as though Crusaders rugby league would become another fading memory — another name added to the long list of clubs lost to the game.

But this club has something many others never had.

It has supporters who simply refuse to let it die.

Not once. But twice.

For those of us who first followed Celtic Crusaders back in 2006, the journey has been a rollercoaster from the very beginning. There were days when it felt like rugby league had finally established a genuine foothold in Wales. Everything pointed towards growth, ambition and Super League dreams.

Yet throughout Crusaders history there has also been a recurring problem. Too often the club found itself in the hands of chancers, crooks and charlatans who promised the world but never truly understood what the club meant to its supporters.

From Bridgend to Wrexham, then Colwyn Bay and beyond, the story has repeated itself. Built up, knocked down, rebuilt once more.

And every single version of Crusaders had good people at its heart. Genuine rugby league people. Volunteers, supporters and staff who poured their lives, time and emotion into keeping the club alive.

Sadly, the people with the money rarely shared the same passion.

There is no doubt the people involved with the South Wales version of Crusaders would have done everything they could to preserve the club. But history has shown how difficult it is for professional rugby league to survive in South Wales. From Bridgend/Cardiff RLFC to South Wales Scorpions, West Wales Raiders and Celtic itself, clubs have come and gone.

But in the north of Wales there remains a fire that refuses to go out.

Perhaps geography helps. Being closer to rugby league's heartlands undoubtedly matters, as does the willingness of players to travel into North Wales. Yet more important than anything else is the support base itself — people who care too deeply to let Crusaders disappear.

They rescued the club when the original Crusaders collapsed.

And they have rescued it again in 2026.

I will never forget where I was when the original club folded. I was at work when the news broke, and it genuinely hurt. It felt like something important had been ripped away.

Then came the creation of North Wales Crusaders, and suddenly there was hope again. Optimism returned. A competitive side was built and there were many memorable days along the way.

Then, only weeks ago, came another hammer blow when Eggchasers pulled out with immediate effect.

Despite winning League 1 last season, rumours quickly spread that Crusaders would follow clubs such as Featherstone Rovers, Halifax Panthers and today's visitors Salford Red Devils into uncertainty and chaos.

But once again, the people who truly love Crusaders rugby league stood together and refused to let it die.

This time, though, there is a feeling that things may finally be different. Rugby league people are back at the forefront of the club. People who understand the supporters, understand the history, and understand what this badge means.

Today is not about bitterness or blame.

Today is about celebrating survival.

It is about remembering the good people from both north and south who helped shape this extraordinary story. People like the Nightingales and Jarrad Vanagas during the Celtic Crusaders years, and familiar North Wales figures such as Paula Evans, Fatty Lewis, Ginger Mike, Simon Jones and Maggsy — supporters and personalities who became friends as much as fellow fans.

Because Crusaders has always been more than a club.

It has been a community.

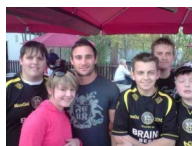
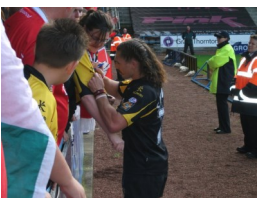
And perhaps one day, every person who ever called themselves a Crusader can come together again under one banner.

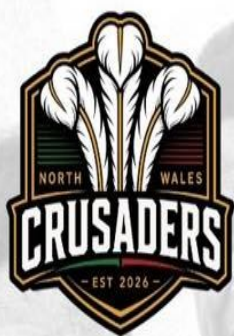
That would be a beautiful moment.

Because through every collapse, every setback and every resurrection, one truth has remained constant:

We are the club that wouldn't die.

UP THE CRU!





PARTNERSHIP ANNOUNCEMENT

NORTH WALES CRUSADERS & HUMMEL

LET'S PLAY

2026-2031





WOMEN

LEAGUE TABLE AND FIXTURES 2026

TEAM	P	W	L	D	F	A	DIFF	PTS
BRONTE BARBARIANS	3	3	0	0	130	36	94	6
WIGAN ST PATRICKS	1	1	0	0	76	0	76	2
OLDHAM	2	1	1	0	68	40	28	2
CRUSADERS	1	1	0	0	22	12	10	2
YORK ACORN	2	1	1	0	28	54	-26	2
CROSFIELDS	2	0	2	0	22	66	-44	0
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	3	0	3	0	8	146	-138	-1

OPPOSITION	V	F	A	ATT	COMP	DATE	KO
CROSFIELDS	A	22	12	N/K	NL3	SUN 17th MAY	14:00
OLDHAM	H				NL3	SUN 7th JUN	11:30
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	H				NL3	SUN 14th JUN	14:00
YORK ACORN	A				NL3	SUN 28th JUN	14:00
BRONTE BARBRIANS	A				NL3	SUN 26th JUL	14:00
BRONTE BARBARIANS	H				NL3	SUN 2nd AUG	14:00
WIGAN ST PATRICKS	H				NL3	SUN 9th AUG	14:00
CROSFIELDS	H				NL3	SUN 16th AUG	14:00
OLDHAM	A				NL3	SUN 23rd AUG	14:00
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	A				NL3	SUN 6th SEP	14:00
YORK ACORN	H				NL3	SUN 13th SEP	14:00





CHAMPIONSHIP

LEAGUE TABLE AND FIXTURES 2026

TEAM	P	W	L	D	F	A	DIFF	PTS
LONDON BRONCOS	12	12	0	0	691	106	585	24
NEWCASTLE THUNDER	13	10	3	0	517	208	309	20
OLDHAM	12	10	2	0	410	157	253	20
BARROW RAIDERS	13	10	3	0	365	209	156	20
WIDNES VIKINGS	12	9	3	0	308	204	104	18
DONCASTER	12	8	4	0	403	176	227	16
SHEFFIELD EAGLES	13	8	5	0	269	336	-67	16
MIDLANDS H/CANES	13	7	5	1	282	332	-50	15
DEWSBURY RAMS	13	7	6	0	310	243	67	14
BATLEY BULLDOGS	12	6	6	0	369	279	90	12
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	13	4	7	2	347	294	53	10
ROCHDALE HORNETS	13	5	8	0	221	398	-177	10
HUNSLET	12	4	8	0	272	330	-58	8
SALFORD	12	4	8	0	194	460	-266	8
WORKINGTON TOWN	13	3	9	1	228	362	-134	7
WHITEHAVEN	13	3	9	1	184	373	-189	7
GOOLE VIKINGS	13	3	10	0	272	465	-193	6
SWINTON LIONS	12	2	9	1	208	436	-228	5
HALIFAX PANTHERS	12	4	8	0	246	330	-84	-4
CRUSADERS	12	3	9	0	238	636	-398	-6

OPPOSITION	V	F	A	ATT	COMP	DATE	KO
SWINTON LIONS	H	31	12	448	F	SUN 21st DEC	15:00
BARROW RAIDERS	A	20	50	1200	F	SUN 28th DEC	15:00
WIGAN WARRIORS	H	30	18	1509	F	SUN 10th JAN	15:00
BEDFORD TIGERS	H	110	0	389	CC	SUN 25th JAN	15:00
WIDNES VIKINGS	A	14	28	4018	L	SUN 1st FEB	15:00
LEIGH LEOPARDS	H	6	60	1899	CC	SUN 7th FEB	15:00
SWINTON LIONS	H	48	20	424	L	SUN 14th FEB	15:00
NEWCASTLE THUNDER	A	30	20	400	L	SUN 22nd FEB	15:00
LONDON BRONCOS	A	18	106		L	SUN 28th FEB	15:00



CHAMPIONSHIP FIXTURES 2026

OPPOSITION	V	F	A	ATT	COMP	DATE	KO
BATLEY BULLDOGS	H	16	30		L	SUN 8th MAR	15:00
HALIFAX PANTHERS	H	22	50	1778	L	SUN 22nd MAR	15:00
WHITEHAVEN	H	52	20		L	SUN 29th MAR	15:00
MIDLANDS HURRICANES	H	18	56	300	L	SUN 5th APR	15:00
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	A	10	66		L	SUN 12th APR	15:00
DONCASTER	A	P	P		L	SUN 3rd MAY	15:00
GOOLE VIKINGS	A	0	80	352	L	SAT 8th MAY	15:00
BATLEY BULLDOGS	A	10	110		L	SAT 24th MAY	15:00
SALFORD	H				L	SUN 31st MAY	15:00
LONDON BRONCOS	H				L	SUN 7th JUN	15:00
WHITEHAVEN	A				L	SUN 14th JUN	15:00
HALIFAX PANTHERS	H				L	SUN 21st JUN	15:00
SALFORD	A				L	SUN 5th JUL	15:00
WIDNES VIKINGS	H				L	SUN 12th JUL	15:00
NEWCASTLE THUNDER	H				L	SUN 19th JUL	15:00
GOOLE VIKINGS	H				L	SUN 2nd AUG	15:00
SWINTON LIONS	A				L	SUN 16th AUG	15:00
KEIGHLEY COUGARS	H				L	SUN 23rd AUG	15:00
MIDLANDS HURRICANES	A				L	SUN 30th AUG	15:00



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IN THE FAN ZONE

 **1PM**

 **31ST MAY**
BEFORE THE
SALFORD GAME

 **JAMIE EL-KALEH**
WILL UPDATE FANS ON
LATEST DEVELOPMENTS



#TEAMCRU

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IN PARTNERSHIP WITH 

OUR CLUB

OUR COMMUNITY

OUR FUTURE

TOGETHER AS ONE



WHEELCHAIR

LEAGUE TABLE AND FIXTURES 2026

TEAM	P	W	L	D	F	A	DIFF	PTS
BATLEY BULLDOGS	3	3	0	0	170	129	41	6
ROCHDALE HORNETS	2	2	0	0	93	74	19	4
CASTLEFORD TIGERS	2	1	1	0	144	71	73	2
GRAVESEND D/MITE	3	1	2	1	162	122	40	2
CRUSADERS	2	1	1	0	92	74	18	2
MIDLANDS H/CANES	3	1	2	0	128	110	18	2
YORK	3	1	2	0	112	175	-63	2
WAKEFIELD TRINITY	2	0	0	2	42	188	-148	0

OPPOSITION	V	F	A	ATT	COMP	DATE	KO
ROCHDALE HORNETS	A	44	46		L	SAT 25th APR	
MIDLANDS HURRICANES	H	48	26		L	SAT 11th APR	
GRAVESEND DYNAMITE	H				L	SAT 6th JUN	11:45
YORK	A				L	SAT 20th JUN	14:00
WAKEFIELD TRINITY	H				L	SAT 27th JUN	12:45
BATLEY BULLDOGS	A				L	SAT 4th JUL	15:00
ROCHDALE HORNETS	H				L	SAT 11th JUL	11:45
MIDLND HURRICANES	A				L	SAT 18th JUL	12:30
YORK	H				L	SAT 8th AUG	11:45
GRAVESEND DYNAMITE	A				L	SAT 15th AUG	14:00
CASTLEFORD TIGERS	A				L	SAT 22nd AUG	14:00
BATLEY BULLDOGS	H				L	SAT 5th SEP	11:45
WAKEFIELD TRINITY	A				L	SAT 12th SEP	14:00





TODAY'S TEAMS



NORTH WALES CRUSADERS

P&L ACCOUNTANCY - JAMES FARRAR

DUBCAT - MATTHEW LIGHTFOOT

SUPERFLY SPORTS FLAGS - EVAN ROWLANDS

FRASER ROBERTSON - LEWIS HOLGATE

NWC WHEELCHAIR & DISABILITY CLUB - JAYDEN BILLY

SUPPORTERS SYNDICATE - BEN FISHER

SUPPORTERS SYNDICATE - JAMIE FOZZARD

KYLE JONES WELLS - CONNOR TERRILL

MAELOR CONSTRUCTION - JAMIE BILLSBOROUGH

SUPPORTERS SYNDICATE - EOIN BOWIE

PAUL DARYL PHOTOGRAPHY - WILL MCCARDLE

SUPPORTERS SYNDICATE - LOGAN STOTT

MH TAYTOES - DOMINIC HORN

JAMIE EL-KALEH - WILL FERNLEY

NWC WOMEN - HARRY COLEMAN

CHARITY TBC - CHARLES TETLEY

CHARITY TBC - MATT BAILEY

GERMAN EXILES - CALLAM LOWE

THE TURF WREXHAM - SEAN LONG

1

2

3

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SALFORD

KEIRON DIXON

JACOB DOUGLAS

OLLIE GARMSTON

JOE HARTLEY

DANIEL SARBAH

GEORGE WHITBY

TOBY HUGHES

SAM BOWRING

BRAD DWYER

JACK BIBBY

COLE OAKLEY

REECE STANTON

CAMERON BATE

JOE BALDWIN

SHAUN COSTELLO

OWEN HALDENBY

OWAIN ABEL

DANNY LYNCH

COACH

DAVE HEWITT

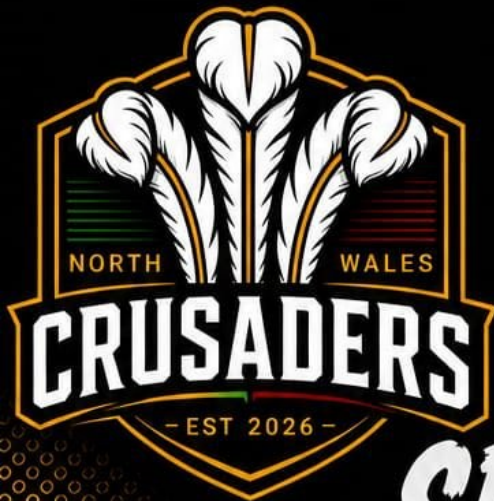


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| 18 |
| £50 + VAT |

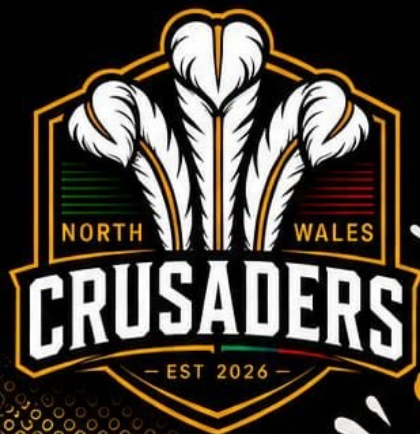


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DRINKS ON
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AT HALF TIME



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- ✓ 4 x complimentary hospitality tickets
- ✓ Round of drinks on arrival and at half time
- ✓ Photo opportunity on the day

£375
+ VAT

PER GAME

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DRINKS ON
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- ✓ Company name & logo on matchday announcements
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- ✓ Social media recognition
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- ✓ Round of drinks on arrival

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+ VAT

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PLAYER OF THE MATCH SPONSOR

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RECOGNISE GREAT PERFORMANCE.

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- ✓ PA announcement
- ✓ Presentation photo with the player
- ✓ 2 x complimentary hospitality tickets
- ✓ Round of drinks on arrival

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+ VAT

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TOGETHER, WE ARE CRUSADERS! ♥

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CRU IN ACTION

V GOOLE VIKINGS (A)

James Chesney at Victoria Pleasure Grounds

North Wales Crusaders could only confirm on Friday evening that they would be able to fulfil the fixture against Goole Vikings.

A huge amount of work behind the scenes ensured the club travelled to the Victoria Pleasure Grounds with a squad assembled at short notice and without the benefit of training together beforehand.

Backed by a loud and passionate travelling support, the Crusaders players gave everything against a vastly experienced Goole Vikings side. With the likes of 400-game veteran Lim Watts, former England international Brett Ferres and the influential Jack Miller in their ranks, the home side always carried a significant advantage in both quality and cohesion.

Inevitably, the Crusaders spent long periods on the back foot, but the final score should not overshadow the commitment and determination shown throughout the contest. Every player contributed wholeheartedly, making it difficult to single out individuals, as the entire squad can take pride in their efforts under extremely challenging circumstances.

The game began in unfortunate fashion for the visitors when the kick-off went directly into touch, handing Widnes an early opportunity which they quickly converted into points through Connor Barley. By half-time, the Vikings had crossed for six tries to establish a commanding 32-0 lead.

Despite the scoreboard, the Crusaders emerged for the second half determined to fight for every moment and search for points of their own. The score had reached 48-0 when the visitors came closest to breaking through, with James Billsborough producing a strong dart towards the posts before being held up agonisingly over the line.

As the game wore on, the physical toll on the Crusaders squad began to show and Goole capitalised late on, eventually recording a club-record score with 15 tries. However, while the result was a difficult one, the spirit, resilience and commitment displayed by North Wales Crusaders offered genuine encouragement. If the dedication shown at the Victoria Pleasure Grounds is carried forward in the weeks ahead, the club can look towards making significant progress.

North Wales Crusaders: Isaac Wheatley, Lewis Holgate, Evan Rowlands, Leo Skerrett-Evans, James Farrar, Brad Billsborough, Ben Dean, Harry Coleman, Jamie Billsborough, Charles Tetley, Eoin Bowie, Will McCardle, Connor Terrill.

Subs: Ben Fisher, Matthew Lightfoot, Logan Scott, Jamie Fozzard.





CRU IN ACTION

V BATLEY BULLDOGS (A)

Batley proved far too strong for a Crusaders side many feared may not even be able to continue in the competition following recent financial problems. The Bulldogs ran in 20 tries, with Reynolds kicking 15 conversions and adding two tries of his own in a dominant personal display.

Crusaders spent much of the second half pinned in their own half, desperately trying to contain wave after wave of Batley attacks as fatigue began to take its toll. To their credit, the visitors still managed to score once in each half.

The Crusaders arrived on the back of five successive defeats in all competitions and had failed to score in their previous three outings. Batley sensed vulnerability from an opposition side still adjusting to significant recent changes, and they ruthlessly took advantage.

The Bulldogs stormed up the slope before the break with eight tries, then completely overwhelmed their opponents after half-time, adding another 12 scores at almost three-minute intervals.

North Wales fielded a vastly changed side from the one beaten 80-0 by Goole a fortnight earlier.

Batley opened the scoring when Robbie Butterworth spotted space out wide and straightened his run to touch down. Derrell Olpherts soon threatened again, powering through two tackles before finally being stopped just short.

Nyle Flynn burrowed over for the second try before Akim Matvejev grabbed the first of his two scores and Ollie Greensmith crossed as Batley raced ahead at more than a point a minute.

After a second handling error from a kick-off, North Wales briefly hit back through Dom Horn, with Ben Fisher converting.

There were occasional signs of complacency from the hosts, with a handful of unforced handling errors and a casual reaction to a Reynolds restart that found touch but gained little ground. However, it did little to halt Batley's momentum as Flynn, Jonah Parsons and Joe Burton all crossed before the interval.

At 44-6 at half-time, and with Batley set to attack downhill in the second period, the only real question inside Mount Pleasant was how large the winning margin would become.

Jack Hudson produced arguably the try of the game immediately after the restart with a weaving solo effort, before another superb run to the line followed shortly afterwards, with Burton also grabbing his second in between.

Batley added 12 second-half tries in total. Lucas Walshaw, Reynolds and Olpherts each scored doubles, while Butterworth, Evan Hodgson and Matvejev also added further scores.

Olpherts' final try left him just one short of the 150-try milestone for his career.

Lewis Holgate did at least provide another moment of consolation for the Crusaders when he crossed in the corner in the 51st minute, but it did little to stem the tide on a difficult afternoon for the brave but exhausted visitors.



TODAYS VISITORS

SALFORD

There are rugby league clubs with bigger trophy cabinets than Salford. There are clubs with larger crowds, richer owners, and shinier modern histories. But few clubs in the sport carry quite the same feeling of endurance.

Salford are rugby league in its rawest form. Proud, stubborn, working class, and forever fighting against the odds.

Founded in 1873, the club has existed almost as long as organised rugby itself. Through different names, different grounds, and different eras, Salford have survived industrial decline, financial collapse, changing sports landscapes, and the repeated suggestion that they should simply disappear. Yet somehow, they have always found a way to keep going.

For older supporters, the glory years still burn brightly. The 1930s side, led by the legendary Gus Risman, played some of the finest rugby league Britain had ever seen. Salford became champions, Challenge Cup winners, and one of the giants of the northern game. In those days, the club stood shoulder to shoulder with the great powers of rugby league. They were the first club to be invited to tour France who saw them as the premier side in the game. After a clean sweep winning all six games, they earned their nickname Les Diables Rouges (The Red Devils) by the French press.

But rugby league history is cruel. Success rarely lasts forever unless money, infrastructure, and stability follow it.

As decades passed, Salford slowly slipped from the elite. Bigger clubs emerged. Crowds declined. Financial pressures mounted. The sport itself changed around them. Yet the club always retained its identity — gritty, local, and fiercely loyal to its community.

For generations, The Willows was the spiritual home of the club. It was not glamorous, but rugby league grounds were never meant to be glamorous. They were places of noise, cigarette smoke, muddy terraces, and hard men playing hard sport. The Willows represented Salford perfectly.

When the club left for the new stadium now shared with rugby union side Sale Sharks at the AJ Bell, many supporters feared something important had been lost. Modern stadiums bring comfort, but not always soul. Even today, there are Salford fans who believe the club never truly recovered from leaving its old home behind.

And yet there have still been moments of hope.

The arrival of former owner Marwan Koukash changed everything for a while. Suddenly Salford were ambitious again. Big-name players arrived. Expectations rose. The club reached finals, challenged stronger sides, and briefly looked capable of becoming genuine contenders. For supporters who had endured decades of struggle, it felt like the future had finally arrived.

But rugby league has a habit of punishing clubs who stretch beyond their means.

After Koukash left, financial instability returned repeatedly. Ownership uncertainty became normal. Promises of investment came and went. Behind the scenes, the club often seemed to exist in permanent crisis mode. Late wage payments, HMRC issues, salary cap restrictions, and constant rumours about survival became part of the weekly news cycle.



The tragedy is that this instability often arrived during periods when the team itself was punching above its weight. Under coach Paul Rowley, Salford played some of the most entertaining rugby league in Britain despite operating on one of the smallest budgets in Super League. They reached major semi-finals and earned enormous respect across the game. Neutrals admired them because they represented what rugby league likes to think it is about, spirit over money, teamwork over glamour.

But eventually, reality catches up.

The financial collapse of 2025 felt like the culmination of years of unresolved problems. Unpaid tax bills, delayed wages, player departures, fan protests, and ownership chaos pushed the club to the brink. By December 2025, the company running the club had been wound up, bringing an end to Salford's 152-year existence in its current form.

For many supporters, it was heartbreaking but not surprising. The warnings had been there for years. Even rival fans expressed sadness because rugby league understands what clubs like Salford mean to the sport. Lose clubs rooted in traditional communities and rugby league loses part of its identity. Reddit discussions at the time were filled with fans calling the situation "sad but inevitable," while others insisted "Salford Rugby never dies."

And that is the key point.

Salford's story has never really been about just silverware. It has been about survival.

The future of rugby league may feel uncertain just now, especially for club outside of Super League. But rugby league has seen rebirth before. Bradford Bulls collapsed and rebuilt. Clubs have disappeared and returned under new ownership and new identities. Salford, and ourselves at Crusaders, are in the same boat. We both need to build something more sustainable from the ruins.

Perhaps that is what we need most. Not another wealthy owner promising dreams they cannot deliver, but stability. Clubs rooted properly in our communities, living within our means, accepting what it is rather than chasing what we cannot afford to become.

Because rugby league needs clubs outside of Super League to thrive.

The sport was built in places that represent its people — industrial towns and working-class communities where rugby league was more than entertainment. It was identity. Salford have represented that identity for over 150 years. Through good times and terrible ones, supporters kept turning up.

That loyalty deserves a future.

Maybe Salford will never again become one of rugby league's dominant powers. Maybe the modern game is too financially brutal for that. But if the club can emerge again with honesty, proper leadership, and realistic ambition, there is still a place for it in the sport.

And if rugby league knows anything at all, it knows this:

You should never write off Salford completely.



VS

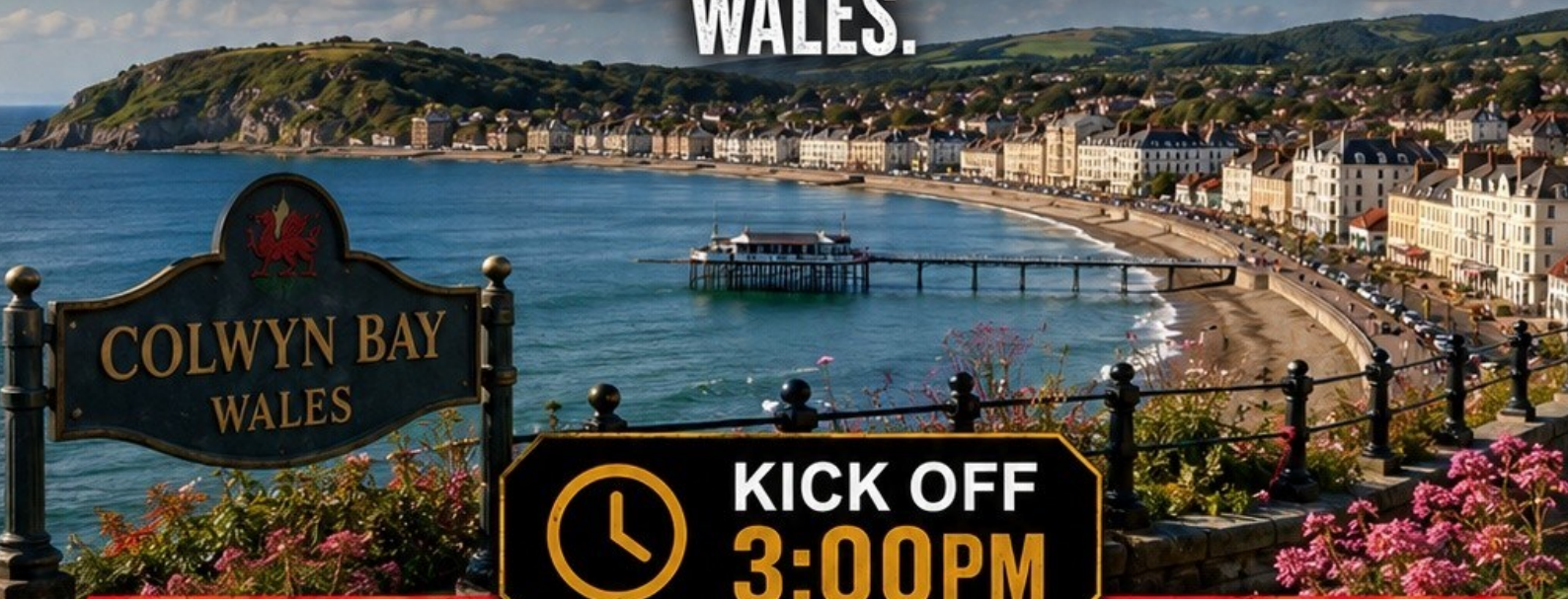


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